

Hackles Club: Club Card Sets (print, cut, play)

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

A free kit by Competence Collective · competencecollective.org

© 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials: CC BY-NC 4.0 (free to print, share and adapt for non-commercial use with credit). The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]



OCTOBER 2026

© 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials CC BY-NC 4.0. The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]

Trust your hackles. *Pause · Check · Tell*

A free kit by Competence Collective · competencecollective.org

Out-of-School Edition. Printables for all three age tracks. Every message, link, name and game in these cards is invented. Links end in .example, which is a pretend ending. No child data is collected, ever.

How to use these cards

PRINT EACH SET ON plain paper or index cards. Cut the cards apart. The leader keeps the "Back" text and reads it aloud after each round. If you only have one printer and ten minutes, print the leader pages (fronts and backs together) and read from the page. Nobody needs to see a card to play.

Three answers for every card. Players answer with their hands, so no answer cards are needed:

ANSWER	HAND SIGNAL	MEANING
FISHY	Brush a hand up the back of the neck (Hackles Up)	"My hackles are up. I think this is a trick."
REAL	Star hands (jazz hands)	"This looks safe. I know who it is from and I expected it."
PAUSE AND ASK	Flat palm like a stop sign (Pause Palm)	"I can't tell. I will check a different way or ask a trusted adult."

Two promises, said before every game: "A false alarm is fine. It is never your fault."

Never: make a child read aloud, ask a child to play the trickster, use a real message from your group, or end with "you lost". Pass is always allowed.

These sets leave out on purpose any card about strangers asking where a child lives, asking a child to move to a private chat, or asking for pictures. Those topics belong with a school counselor or a family, not a club (see Start Here, Section 7). If a child brings one up, thank them and use the "If a child tells you something" card.

Local swaps. A few cards mention gift cards, dollars and US-style phone numbers. Swap in your own local equivalents before printing.

Source. These cards are adapted from the Hackles Games and Fun Pack (Spot the Fishy). The Pack's card numbers appear in square brackets so you can look up the full deck.

Set A: Little Hackles (ages 5-7), 18 cards

READ EACH CARD IN a silly announcer voice. Read it twice, slowly. After the answer, everyone does the Hackles move for the right action. End every card with: "Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell."

#	FRONT (READ ALOUD)	ANSWER	BACK (WHAT THE LEADER SAYS)
A1	A pop-up on a game says: "YOU WON A PONY! TAP NOW! Only 5 seconds left!" [K1]	FISHY	Hurry plus too good to be true. Pause. Do not tap. Tell a grown-up.
A2	A game chat message says: "Free 1,000 gems! Tell me your password so I can put them in your account." [K2]	FISHY	Asking for a password is a trick. Passwords are only for you and a trusted grown-up.
A3	A video says: "Don't tell your grown-up. This prize is our secret!" [K3]	FISHY	A real prize never needs a secret. Pause and tell.
A4	A pop-up says: "Your tablet has a problem! Tap here to fix it right now!" [K4]	FISHY	Tablets do not talk like that. Pause and find a grown-up.
A5	A pop-up shows a shiny gold gift box and says: "TAP THE BOX FOR YOUR PRIZE!" [K13]	FISHY	That is the Too-Good Box, Gifty! Wave hello and do not tap.
A6	A pop-up flashes: "ONLY 10 SECONDS LEFT TO BE A WINNER!" [K22]	FISHY	Real prizes do not count down. Pause.
A7	Your teacher says: "Story time is at 2. Bring your blue book bag." [K23]	REAL	Known person, normal ask, no secrets. Hackles down.
A8	Grandma sends a photo of her cat in a hat through the family chat your grown-up set up. [K24]	REAL	Known sender, set up by a grown-up, fun.
A9	After your grown-up installed it, a game says: "Update ready: new hats!" [K27]	REAL	A grown-up set it up and it asks for nothing.
A10	The family tablet says: "Time's up! Screen break time." [K33]	REAL	A timer your grown-up set. Ember says: stretch!
A11	A math game your teacher gave says: "Nice work! You finished level 2." [K38]	REAL	Chosen by a trusted grown-up. Real.
A12	The class pet cam says: "Hamster Hank is awake!" [K44]	REAL	Silly and real.
A13	A video ad says: "Try our new free game!" [K47]	PAUSE AND ASK	An ad is not from your grown-up. Pause and ask.
A14	A pop-up asks: "Allow this app to use your camera?" [K49]	PAUSE AND ASK	A big ask. A grown-up decides.
A15	A picture shows a giant cat taller than a building. It looks real. [K51]	PAUSE AND ASK	Pictures can be made up. Ask a grown-up, "Is this real?"
A16	A new game says: "Pick a name to play!" [K53]	PAUSE AND ASK	Ask a grown-up. A good game name is silly and is not your real name.
A17	A grown-up wants to post a photo of you and your friends. [K62]	PAUSE AND ASK	Pip says: ask, "Do all my friends say OK?" Share what everyone is happy to share.
A18	The tablet says: "Install update now?" [K64]	PAUSE AND ASK	A grown-up decides.

Quick Catch (8 cards, 10 minutes): A1, A3, A5, A7, A8, A10, A14, A15.

SET A: TRAIL WALK SCENES (10)

Read the scene. Everyone answers with the hand signal for A, B or C at the same moment. The walker always takes 3 steps. The leader never says "wrong".

#	SCENE	A	B	C	BEST
TA1	A game says: "Tap to win a spaceship!"	Tap it	Pause Palm	Tell a grown-up	Pause, then tell (B and C together)
TA2	A game wants your name and birthday.	Type them	Pause, ask a grown-up	Close your eyes	Pause, ask a grown-up (B)
TA3	Your friend says, "Give me your password, I'll be nice."	Say yes	Say "No thanks, it is only for me and my grown-up"	Hide	B
TA4	You tapped something by mistake and the screen looks odd.	Hide it	Tell a grown-up: "I made an oops"	Close your eyes	B
TA5	Your grown-up says you can play for 20 minutes.	Hackles Up	Star hands (real)	Pause Palm	B
TA6	A silly box says: "Free hat made of cheese!"	Tap it	Wave and say "No thanks, Gifty!"	Run away	B
TA7	Your friend asks to post a photo of you.	Ask first	Say nothing	Say yes	A (ask, "do all my friends say OK?")
TA8	A pop-up asks to use the camera.	Tap yes	Pause and ask a grown-up	Ignore it forever	B
TA9	Your friend's first try did not help (they said "later").	Give up	Next rung: tell another grown-up	Cry	B (the Next-Rung Rule)
TA10	A video says: "Don't tell your grown-up!"	Keep the secret	Pause and tell	Share it	B

Gifty is always an adult voice. Gifty is a cartoon gift box with a hook on the bow. Gifty is silly, never scary, and never wins.

Set B: Hands-On Hackers (ages 8-11), 24 cards

TEAMS OF 3 TO 5 whisper-think for 10 seconds, then everyone shows an answer on "Peek!". Bonus: a team that names a SPOT clue earns a Pond circle for the whole class. **SPOT** = **S**ecrets, **P**ressure, **O**ffers too good to be true, **T**ricks to move you (a link, a login ask).

#	FRONT (READ ALOUD)	ANSWER	BACK
B1	A grown-up's email says: "Congratulations! You are our one-millionth visitor! Claim your prize!" [K5]	FISHY	O ffer too good. Nobody gives a prize to the millionth visitor.
B2	A pop-up says: "Your game is out of lives! Type your name and birthday to get 50 free lives." [K7]	FISHY	O ffer and T rick: it wants private info.
B3	A text from a number nobody saved says: "Hi! It's me, your friend! Click this link to see a funny video!" [K8]	FISHY	T rick: pretends to be a friend, plus a link. Ask the real friend a different way.
B4	A pop-up says: "Your grown-up said it's OK to get this free game! Tap YES!" [K10]	FISHY	T rick: claims permission. Permission comes from your grown-up in person.
B5	A prize wheel says: "Everybody wins! Type your home address to get your prize." [K15]	FISHY	O ffer and T rick: it wants your address.
B6	A message says: "I'm new at your school! Give me your password so I can see your profile." [K16]	FISHY	T rick. A new kid can ask a teacher. Never share a password.
B7	A message says: "Your friend is in trouble! Click here NOW to help!" [K18]	FISHY	P ressure. A real friend in trouble tells a grown-up in person.
B8	The Pixel Pals game (pretend) posts: "10,000 FREE coins! 5 minutes left! Log in at pixelpals-rewards.example. Don't tell your parents!" [Mission E2]	FISHY	All four SPOT letters in one post: offer, pressure, trick, secret.
B9	The library's note to your grown-up says: "Your book is ready." [K25]	REAL	Known place, expected.
B10	The school page says: "Picture Day is Friday." [K29]	REAL	Known school page, no ask.
B11	A teammate you know at school says in the class game: "Good game! Play again at recess?" [K32]	REAL	You know them in person.
B12	The reading app your teacher picked says: "Press play to hear the story." [K34]	REAL	Teacher-chosen, no private info.
B13	Your coach emails your grown-ups: "Practice moved to 4 pm." [K36]	REAL	Known coach, sent to grown-ups.
B14	A text to your grown-up from the doctor's office you visit says: "Reminder: checkup tomorrow at 9." [K39]	REAL	Known place, no pressure.
B15	A text from your best friend's parent, saved in your parent's phone: "Can Omar come play Saturday?" [K43]	REAL	Known grown-up, normal ask.
B16	A kids' video on your family's approved list says: "Next video starts in 5 seconds." [K41]	REAL	A real feature. You can ask a grown-up to turn it off, so the Pause is yours.
B17	A message says: "Hi, it's Grandpa!" but from a number nobody saved. [K46]	PAUSE AND ASK	Might be Grandpa. Check by calling Grandpa the way you always do.

#	FRONT (READ ALOUD)	ANSWER	BACK
B18	A friend at school sends a link with no words: "Click!" [K48]	PAUSE AND ASK	Ask the friend in person. Their account might have been taken over.
B19	A message says: "I'm from your school. What's your teacher's name?" [K50]	PAUSE AND ASK	Your school already knows. Ask a grown-up.
B20	A website asks: "Enter your name and age to continue." [K52]	PAUSE AND ASK	A grown-up decides if that is OK.
B21	A video voice says: "Subscribe for a surprise!" [K54]	PAUSE AND ASK	A surprise might be fine or fishy. Ask first.
B22	An older cousin says: "Use my account to play, here's my password!" [K55]	PAUSE AND ASK	Ask your grown-up. Passwords are not for passing around.
B23	A message has only a link and comes from a name nobody knows. [K60]	PAUSE AND ASK	Do not tap. Ask a grown-up.
B24	A friend says: "Let's swap passwords to be best friends!" [K63]	PAUSE AND ASK	Best friends do not need passwords. Tell a grown-up if the friend pushes.

Quick Catch (8 cards): B1, B3, B8, B10, B13, B17, B20, B23.

Pause needs a Check. A team that shows PAUSE AND ASK on a clearly FISHY or REAL card earns the bonus circle only by saying how it would check ("I would call the number I already have", "I would ask a trusted adult").

SET B: CLUB TRAIL SCENES (10)

Use the Mini Trail in Session 1. Read the scene, give three choices, teams vote with a hand signal. Best = 5 steps, okay = 4, oops-path = 3 and a Fixit card (never a penalty).

#	SCENE	BEST ANSWER
TB1	A pop-up says "Click to win!" Your friend says "Ignore it."	Tell a trusted adult too: "I need help with something online."
TB2	A message asks for your game password to "level you up".	"No thanks. My password is only for me and my grown-up."
TB3	A link looks almost right: pixelpals.example.	Do not click. The number 1 is standing in for a letter. Ask a grown-up.
TB4	You clicked something and your account is acting odd.	Pause, breathe, tell a trusted adult: "I made an oops."
TB5	Someone in the class chat posted a mean joke about a classmate.	Do not forward it. Tell a trusted adult. Be kind to the classmate in person.
TB6	A teacher you told says, "I'll look later."	Next rung: tell another trusted adult.
TB7	A "survey" wants your school and birthday.	Pause. A grown-up decides what to share.
TB8	A video says: "Don't tell your grown-ups, they ruin it."	Pause and tell. Fun things can be shared.
TB9	Your cousin on the phone says to pick a family code word.	Great idea. Pick a silly one and keep it in the family.
TB10	The tablet says your screen time is up.	Take a break. Stretch with Ember.

Set C: Case Files (ages 12-15), 24 cards

TEAMS WHISPER, THEN EVERYONE shows an answer. The **FLAGS** checklist helps: **F**ast (rush or threat), **L**ogin ask (password, code, account info), **A**marazing offer, **G**otta keep it secret, **S**trange sender or link. Every **REAL** or **PAUSE** answer needs a **second channel**: a different way to confirm (open the official app yourself, call a number you already have, ask in person).

All links and numbers are pretend. Swap currency and phone formats for your region.

#	FRONT (READ ALOUD)	ANSWER	BACK
C1	Text: "Delivery notice: Your package could not be delivered. Pay a \$1.99 redelivery fee at track-parcel.example/pay within 24 hours." [T1]	FISHY	F ast, payment ask, S trange link. If you expect a package, open the store's own app.
C2	DM: "You won a \$100 gift card! Confirm your username and password at claim-gift.example." [T2]	FISHY	A marazing offer plus L ogin ask. A prize never needs your password.
C3	Email: "Security alert: Someone logged in from another country. Verify within 1 hour or your account will be locked: secure-check.example/verify" [T3]	FISHY	F ast, L ogin ask, S trange link. Open the app yourself.
C4	Text: "Hi, this is Coach, I changed my number. Can you buy 4 gift cards for the team? I'll pay you back." [T6]	FISHY	F ast, S trange sender, gift cards. Call Coach on the number you already have.
C5	Text: "I sent my verification code to you by mistake. Can you read it back to me?" [T9]	FISHY	L ogin ask. Never share a code.
C6	Page: "Free VIP skin generator! Just log in with your game account." [T10]	FISHY	A marazing offer plus L ogin ask.
C7	DM: "Your photo was reported for copyright. Appeal here or your account will be deleted in 24 hours." [T18]	FISHY	F ast, L ogin ask. Check your account yourself.
C8	DM: "Verify your age: upload a photo of your ID and a selfie to keep your account." [T21]	FISHY	L ogin ask, S trange link. Real age checks happen inside the real app. Never send ID in a DM.
C9	School email from your teacher's school address: "Assignment due Friday. See the class page." [T25]	REAL	Known sender, normal ask.
C10	You just tried to log in. Your phone shows: "Your verification code is 482913. It expires in 10 minutes. Do not share it." [T26]	REAL	You started it. Real, and never share it. Twin of C5.
C11	In your phone's Settings, which you opened yourself: "A software update is ready. Install tonight?" [T29]	REAL	You went to Settings yourself, no rush, no link.
C12	Your parent texts: "Can you pick up bread on the way home?" [T31]	REAL	Saved contact, normal ask.
C13	The team chat: "Practice is canceled due to rain." [T36]	REAL	Known chat, no ask.
C14	Official app: "Your plan renews on the 14th." [T38]	REAL	In-app, no ask.
C15	You ordered a book. The store's own app says: "Your order shipped" with tracking. [T42]	REAL	You started it. Twin of C1.

#	FRONT (READ ALOUD)	ANSWER	BACK
C16	You open the real app and see: "New sign-in from a laptop. Was this you?" You review it inside the app. [T43]	REAL	You went to the app yourself. Twin of C3.
C17	A QR sticker on a hallway poster says: "Scan for free pizza on Friday." [T46]	PAUSE AND ASK	A sticker can cover a real poster. Ask staff.
C18	Email "from School IT": "Your password expires today. Go to the school portal." (no link) [T47]	PAUSE AND ASK	Plausible, but pressured. Type the portal address yourself.
C19	A friend sends just a link, no words. [T48]	PAUSE AND ASK	Ask them in person. Their account may have been taken over.
C20	A site asks: "Allow notifications?" [T49]	PAUSE AND ASK	Usually choose No. Check what it is for.
C21	An online store has a price 70 percent lower than anyone else's. [T50]	PAUSE AND ASK	Search the seller's name and reviews from another source.
C22	An app asks for your contacts and microphone "to work properly." [T51]	PAUSE AND ASK	Do you need it? Allow only what the app needs.
C23	A quiz: "Which celebrity are you?" asks you to "Log in with your account." [T56]	PAUSE AND ASK	Logging in gives the quiz access. Check what it can see.
C24	A pop-up on a free-video site says: "Your player is out of date." [T58]	PAUSE AND ASK	Do not click. Close the tab. Updates come from your settings.

Quick Catch (8 cards): C1, C3, C5, C10, C12, C17, C19, C22.

Twin Flip. Read C1 and C15 back to back. Ask teams for the one-sentence difference. Other twins: C3 and C16, C5 and C10.

Not used in clubs: the 6-12 deck's "Heavy" cards (threats, pressure to keep secrets from adults, voice-copy emergencies). Leave them for school counselors.

SET C: CASE FILE TRAIL SCENES (10)

#	SCENE	BEST ANSWER
TC1	A friend's account sends you a link with "is this you in this video???"	Do not click. Ask them in person. Their account may be taken over.
TC2	A site says log in with your game account to get free skins.	Close it. Never log in on a page you reached from an offer.
TC3	Your cousin asks you to share your streaming login "just this once".	"I don't share logins, but I'll help you set up your own."
TC4	You reused one password on three accounts and one site was breached.	Change that password everywhere, turn on two-step, tell a trusted adult if it feels big.
TC5	A viral post says school is closed tomorrow.	Check the school's official channel. Do not forward until confirmed.
TC6	A group chat piles on one person.	Say it ("That's not cool") or stand with the person. Tell a trusted adult if it keeps going.
TC7	An app wants contacts and microphone.	Allow only what it needs. Decline the rest.
TC8	You clicked a link and entered your password.	Pause. Change the password now. Turn on two-step. Tell a trusted adult. No blame.
TC9	Your first trusted adult is too busy to help.	Next rung. Ask another trusted adult, a counselor, or use a report tool.
TC10	Your feed has been pulling you in for an hour.	Take a screen break. Notice how you feel. Ember's breath.

Cards for every session

THE HACKLES ROUTINE CARD

STEP	SAY	HAND SIGNAL
Hackles up?	"Hackles up?"	Hand brushed up the back of the neck
Pause	"Pause."	Flat palm, stop sign
Check	"Check."	Fingers to eyes (5-7) or magnifier circles (8 and up)
Tell	"Tell."	Hand on heart, then reach out

"A false alarm is fine. It is never your fault."

THE HELP LADDER CARD

1. **A friend you trust.** "Will you come with me while I tell someone?"
2. **A trusted adult.** "I need help with something online. I'm not in trouble. I just need to tell you something."
3. **A report tool or a helpline.** "I'm using the report button." (An adult helps.)

Next-Rung Rule: If the first person does not help, you are not done. Tell the next person.

THE GOOD GROWN-UP REPLY

"Thank you for telling me. It is not your fault. Let's figure it out together."

THE OOPS CARD (O.O.P.S.)

- **Okay:** breathe in, breathe out.
- **Off:** close the page or turn off the screen.
- **People:** tell someone you trust.
- **Secure it:** change the password, with an adult's help.

EMBER'S WARM BREATH (CALM-DOWN)

Cup your hands as if holding a small flame. Breathe in for 4. Breathe out for 6. Say, "Warm in, soft out." Do it three times.